Alessandra Balliana

Product Design Lead

Product Design | Strategy | AI | Design Systems

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LINKEDIN

Freedom2hear Head of Product Design, Innovation & Growth • December 2024 to Present

As part of **Senior Leadership Team**, I work closely with the **CTO, COO, and company shareholders.** Responsibilities include:

- **Strategic Alignment:** Collaborating across marketing, product, and technology initiatives to ensure alignment between business objectives, technical requirements, and creative strategies.
- **Product Development:** 0-1 product strategy, leading the AI Labs R&D team to identify and develop innovative solutions, assess and define new business opportunities and their product market fit.
- **Creative and Marketing Growth:** Overseeing creative and marketing initiatives, ensuring consistent messaging and branding across sales, social media, and marketing materials to drive business growth.
- **Collaboration:** Fostering collaboration across design, marketing, and tech teams to maintain alignment and ensure shared focus on company goals, while establishing a shared vision.
- **Research and Insights:** Research activities to guide product and design decisions, while staying informed of industry trends and emerging technologies.

previously Creative & Product Design Lead • January 2024 to December 2024

PwC UK Lead Product Designer (Manager Grade) • November 2022 to November 2023

- **Lead Product Designer and Design System Specialist** on a variety of client engagements and business development projects.
- Consulted for **Ops models and Design System strategies** such as: a design ops blueprint for a Global Professional Services Firm, tokenised multi-brand design system for a British e-commerce retail company, white label design system for a banking app.
- Founded the **Design Systems Community**: led a team to organise talks, meet-ups and provide knowledge sharing opportunities globally.

> You're a truly talented and credible leader in design, with a passion for your craft that is demonstrated through the rigor in your methodology, and your attention to detail. Your knack for turning complex challenges into something simple and straightforward is impressive. And as a strategic storyteller, you shine. Beyond your craft, I admire how you actively learn from others, asking questions, demonstrating your curiosity, and finding ways to work better together.
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> **Lauren Pleydell-Pearce – Chief Creative Officer, PwC**

Resi Lead Product Designer • June 2022 to November 2022

- **Managed** the Design team to work across the **"Design", "Connect"** and **"Finance"** services, while reporting to the **CTO.**
- **Design system**: led workshops and training sessions to introduce atomic design methodologies and tokenised approach for designers and engineers. Led the Tech team throughout the restructuring and improvement of their existing design system with new documentation in Notion.
- **Research**: introduced qualitative research and usability testing within the team's workflows.

> Prior to her, the team had consisted of relatively inexperienced designers who had built the app in quite an ad-hoc, messy way. Ale helped create structure and logic by implementing a design system. Two years after her departure, we have rebranded and built a new design system, but it was Ale's building blocks that created the foundations of how we still work to this day. I would definitely work with Ale again.
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> **Nic Yeeles – VP of Product & Design, Resi**

Tom&Co. Senior UX/UI Designer + Design Systems Manager • July 2019 to June 2022

- **Design systems and DesignOps**: strategy, implementation and management of their internal white label design system which led to **increased team efficiency by 30%**
- Created **bespoke multi-brand design system solutions** for clients
- **Workshops, training sessions, documentation and training material** for design & tech teams covering tools and processes
- **Led end-to-end design** for B2B and B2C e-commerce products, including subscription-based products and services, complex product builders with personalisation features, and CMS-optimised designs
- **Quantitative and qualitative research** – e.g planning and conducting user interviews, creating reports with GA and Hotjar

> She played a key role in establishing our internal design system at Tom&Co during her time on my team. She constantly strives to elevate the standard of design, showcasing her commitment to excellence.
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> **Sara Deambrosis – Head of Design, Tom&Co**

QVC Web & App Designer • June 2019 to July 2019

Jack Wills UX/UI Designer • December 2017 to June 2019

OKA Digital Designer • November 2017 to December 2017

Sofa.com Junior Graphic Designer (Digital & Print) • April 2017 to September 2017

Oddo+Lopez Architetti Architect (Intern) • September 2009 to December 2012

Outside the "9-to-5"

🟧 Flux Community Member

Since January 2025

🎤 Speaker at Government Digital Service's Design System Day 2024

"Dual Narrative: Small vs Large organisations"

5 September 2024 - Liverpool

💜 ADPList Mentor

Free mentorship to Junior designers and graduates (portfolio and CV reviews, career coaching, interview prep)

Since January 2024

What motivates me

Impact
I thrive in multidisciplinary settings, where my work resonates across the business, team, audience, and our society.

Growth
I seek out projects that challenge me to step outside my comfort zone and opportunities for growth.

Influence
Design as an asset to make strategic commercial decisions while creating meaningful experiences that improve people's lives.

Education

2013 – 2016
BMus (Hons) Popular Music Performance – Vocals
ICMP – London, UK

2009 – 2012
Master in Architecture and Interior Design
Politecnico di Milano – Milan, Italy

2010 – 2011
Erasmus+ Programme
Institut Superieur d'Architecture Victor Horta – Bruxelles, Belgium

2006 – 2009
Bachelor Degree in Architecture
Politecnico di Milano – Milan, Italy